

GREAT IDEAS GREAT MINDS

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We need to revive our tradition of **INDIVIDUAL PHILANTHROPY** because giving wisely is the only way of holding on to what is left

European visitors to India in the 16th and 17th centuries usually found precious little to admire here. The climate they deemed too warm and languorous; they rarely liked the food and drink; the gods struck them as frightful and monstrous. Once in a while, however, something did catch their fancy. Amongst these was the Indian habit of giving often and generously, such as when a merchant at the end of his worldly career decided publicly to part with all his material goods. Even the Jesuits, behind their general attitude of superiority and

condescension, occasionally praised the mass feeding of the poor that was practised both in temples and by princes and magnates. Usually they saw all this as a form of ritual or religious practice rather than an affirmation of social bonds. The Dutch and the English merchants in their outposts in places such as Surat and Bharuch were less certain of what these acts of giving meant, and noted in puzzlement that they extended beyond generosity to humans to setting up infirmaries for animals and even birds.

Something happened to this tradition over two centuries of colonial rule. It did not disap-



PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

Social Contract

WITH A NEWLY-AFFLUENT MINORITY, SIMMERING SOCIAL VIOLENCE IS AN EVER-PRESENT REALITY. THE ONLY WAY TO PREVENT THE RISE OF PARANOIA AMONG THE HAVES AND RESENTMENT AGAINST THE HAVE-NOTS IS TO HAVE A NEW ETHIC OF PHILANTHROPY IN PLACE.